

HOW TO CROSS THE RED TAPE

Innovation in a public institution of 3.000 employees

By Gaby Rasters, Romar Bucur

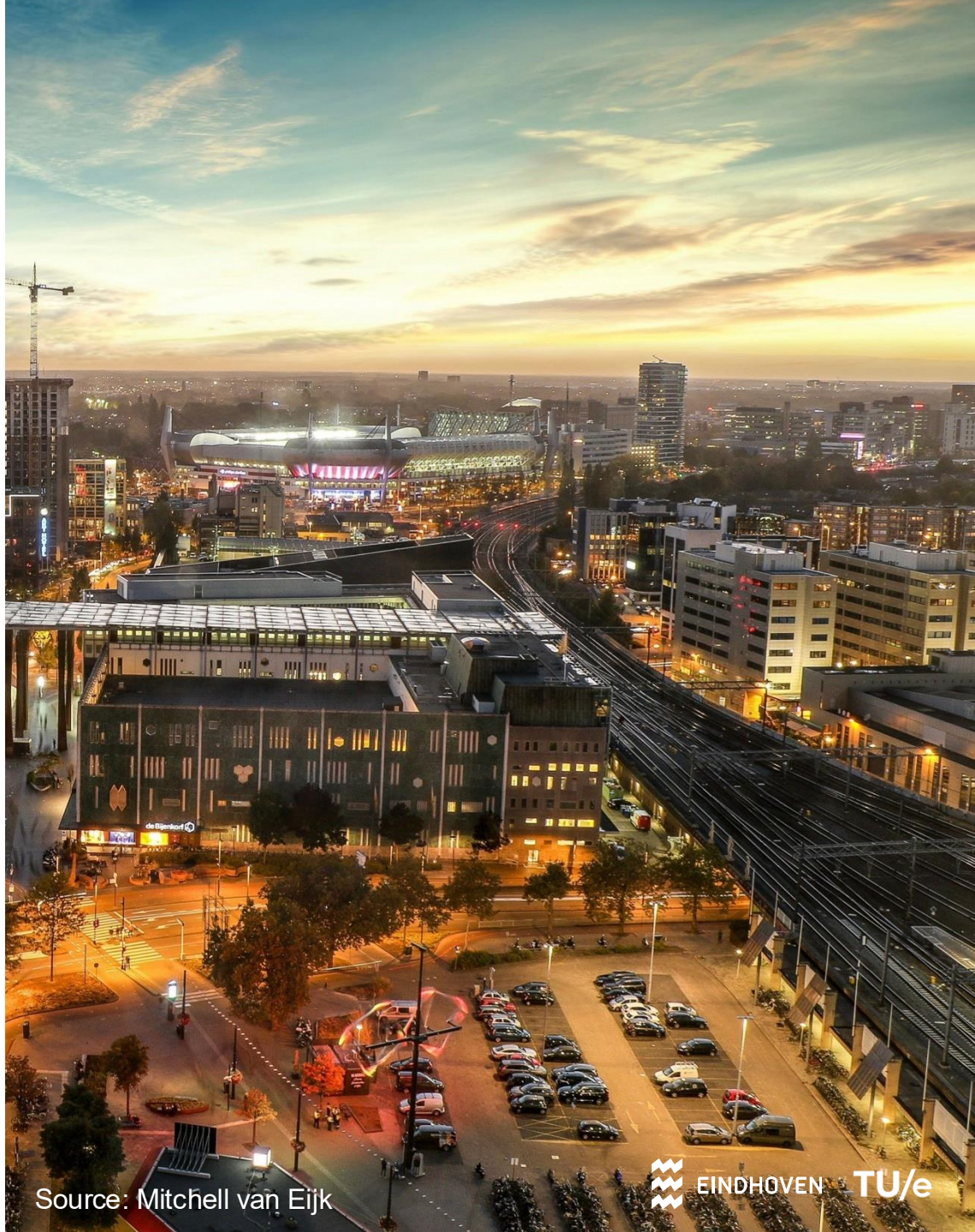
EINDHOVEN TU/e EINDHOVEN UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY

Source: Amvest – Development District E

Who are we?

Municipality of Eindhoven

- ✓ 250.000+ residents
- ✓ 3,000 employees
- ✓ Fastest growing tech region in the Netherlands
- ✓ Responsible for housing, mobility, sustainability, public space, social care, safety, permits and economic development
- ✓ Within the Brainport region and context



Who are we?



Gaby | Strategic Advisor

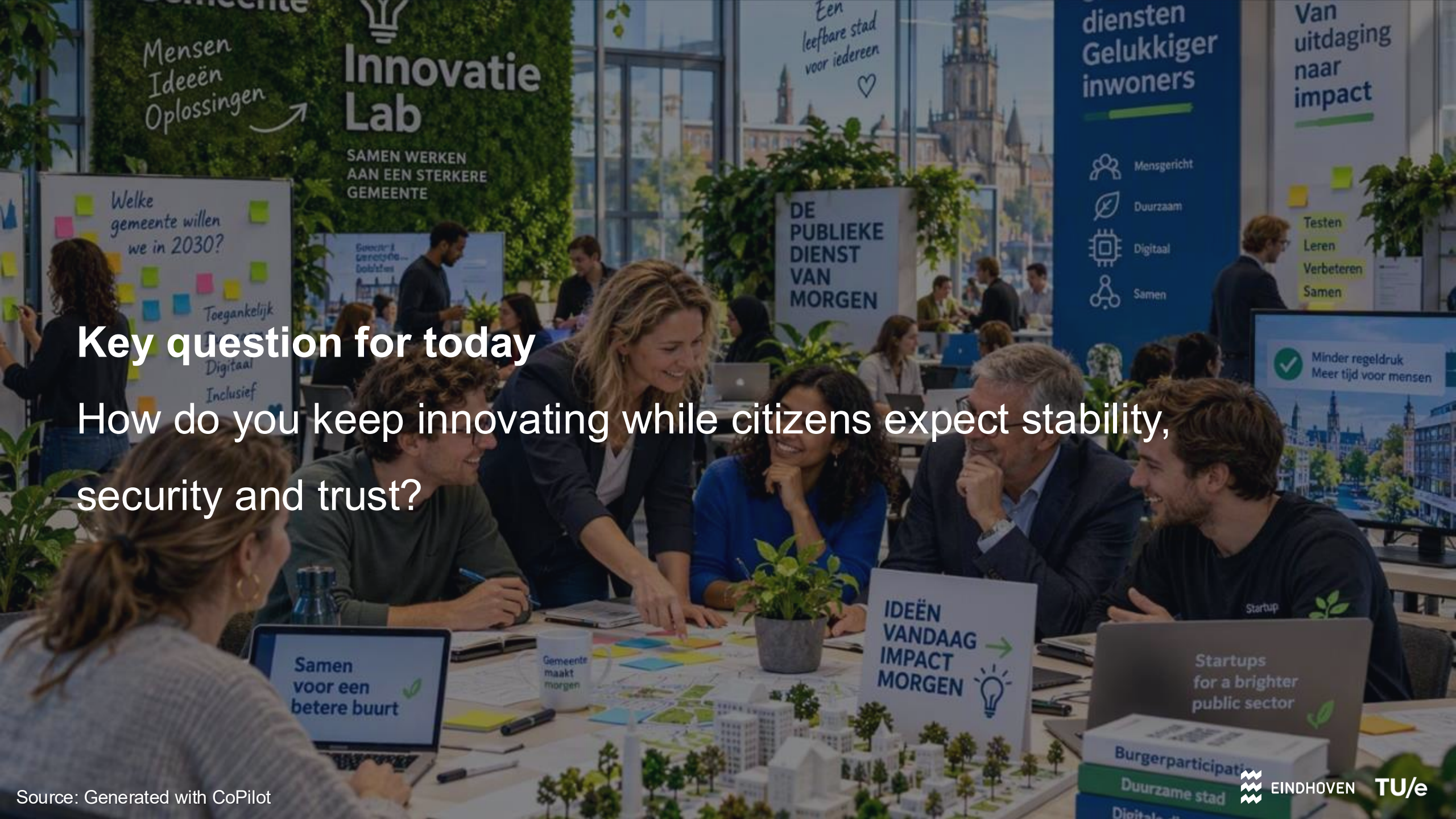
- ✓ 20+ years of experience in local government.
- ✓ Teacher and researcher at TU/e after PhD.
- ✓ Led major innovation and safety initiatives, including for Brainport and Stratumseind Living Lab.
- ✓ Connects strategy, innovation, public safety, and implementation; currently leading a Knowledge & Innovation Agenda.



Romar | Strategic Information Manager

- ✓ 2 years of experience within Eindhoven.
- ✓ Part of CIO Office, AI Centre of Expertise, Digital Europe and Horizon calls.
- ✓ Background 15+ years in media and gaming industry, start-up advisor, entrepreneur, chair innovation board.





Key question for today

How do you keep innovating while citizens expect stability, security and trust?

Source: Generated with CoPilot

Our unique superpower

DNA in Technology, Design and Knowledge. Supported by strong networks in quadruple helix and living labs.

This whole brain ecosystem gives us an unfair advantage in addressing societal and urban challenges.

We help to turn this into impactful innovation.



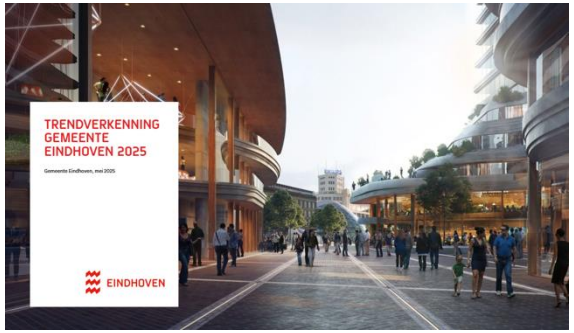
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Our new reality

1. Growing risk of prolonged disruption of critical infrastructure and essential public services.

2. Increasing interconnectedness, system dependencies, and sabotage threats amplify societal impact.

3. Building resilience requires a whole-of-society approach, bringing together government, citizens, and businesses.





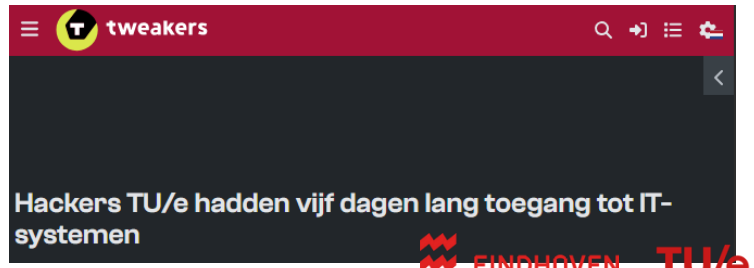




Alexander Leeuw
Economieredacteur

18 mei 2026 om 09:15 1.2K reacties Delen





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The dilemma

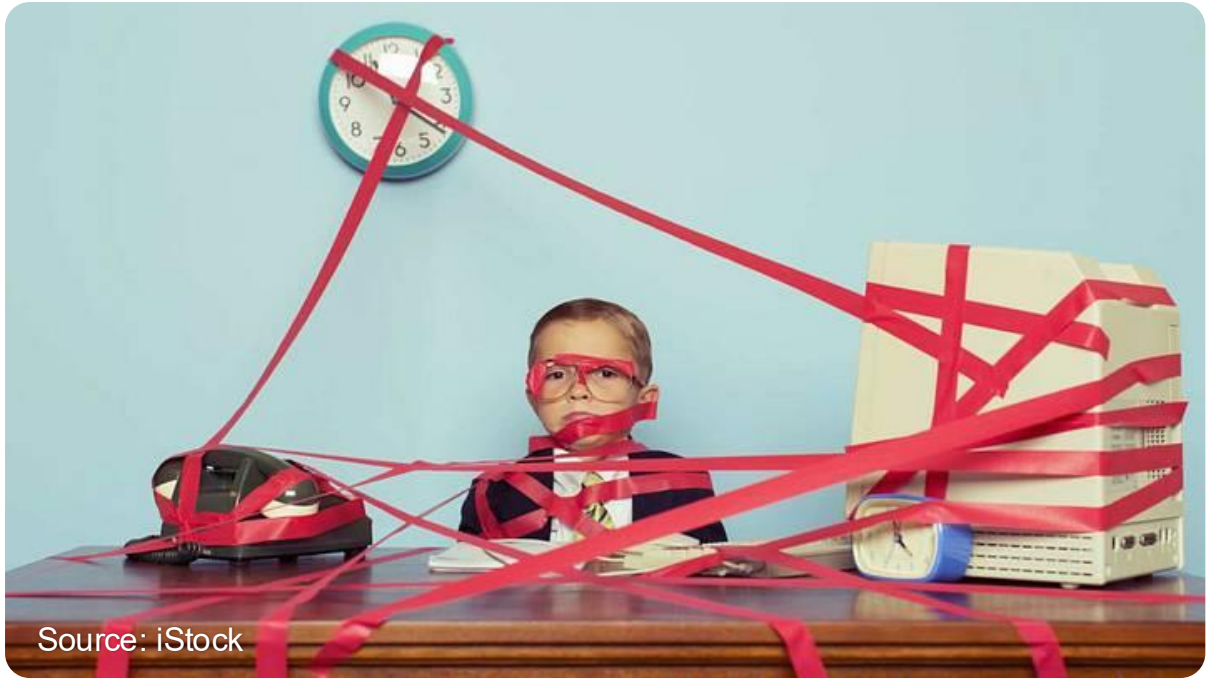
Government innovation is different…

A startup can fail

A municipality cannot

Every innovation must consider:

- ✓ Privacy
- ✓ Security
- ✓ Procurement law
- ✓ Public accountability
- ✓ Political sensitivity
- ✓ Limited budgets
- ✓ Public trust



The Paradox

Society expects government to innovate faster than ever while making zero mistakes.

Being the smartest region was not enough

Historically

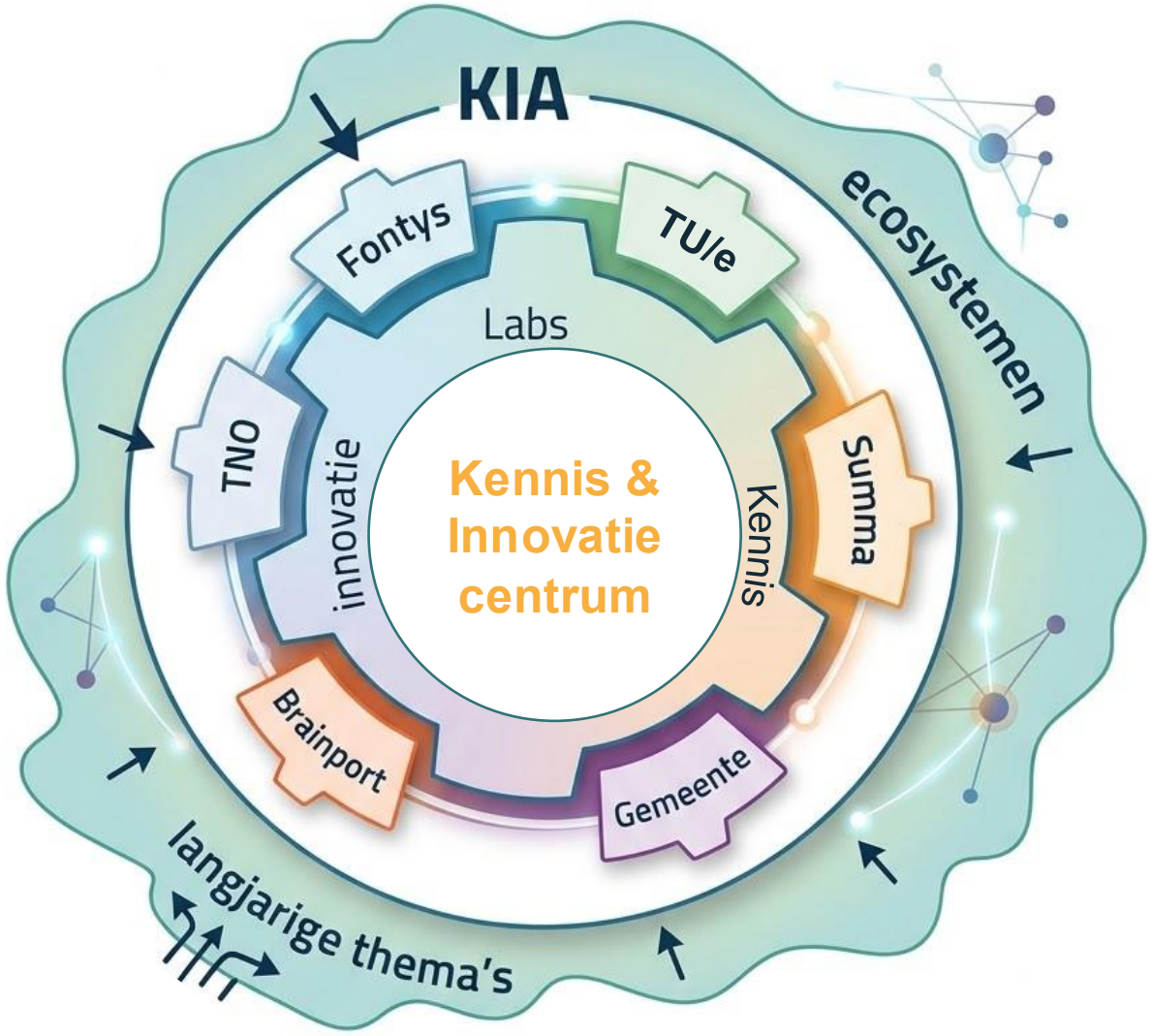
- ✓ Hundreds of innovation initiatives
- ✓ Strong ecosystem
- ✓ Global recognition
- ✓ But limited scaling
- ✓ Not enough organisational learning
- ✓ No central innovation governance
- ✓ Success depended on enthusiasts and our DNA triple helix (and the Brainport strategy!)



Therefore we created KIA and KIC

Today

- ✓ Central innovation governance
- ✓ One innovation desk
- ✓ One portfolio
- ✓ One scaling approach
- ✓ Strong partnerships with knowledge institutions



Our innovation ecosystem

Municipality of Eindhoven as a learning organization and active participant in the ecosystem

Public Sector

Brainport Eindhoven · Brainport voor elkaar · Gemeente Amsterdam · Effenaar · Provincie Noord-Brabant · VNG · BOM · de Bibliotheek Eindhoven · Eindhoven Engine · Brainport Industries Campus

Private sector

Innovation Center Brainport · 3EALITY · High Tech Campus Eindhoven · ASML · NXP

Knowledge and Innovation Agenda (KIA)

The joint mission agenda of the Municipality of Eindhoven, TU/e, Fontys and Summa College

Knowledge and Innovation Center (KIC)

Our Internal collaboration for turning innovation into results

- Research
- Innovation
- Labs

Citizens

Start-ups and SMEs

Knowledge partners

TU/e · Fontys University of Applied Sciences · SiNTLUCAS · DAE Design Academy Eindhoven · SUMMA · TNO innovation for life

Funding Agencies

CitCom.AI · CINC · LDT CitiVERSE EDIC

Why this matters now?

The real driver is not technology.

The real driver is societal pressure

- ✓ Housing shortage
- ✓ Labour shortage
- ✓ Energy transition
- ✓ Digitalization
- ✓ Geopolitical uncertainty

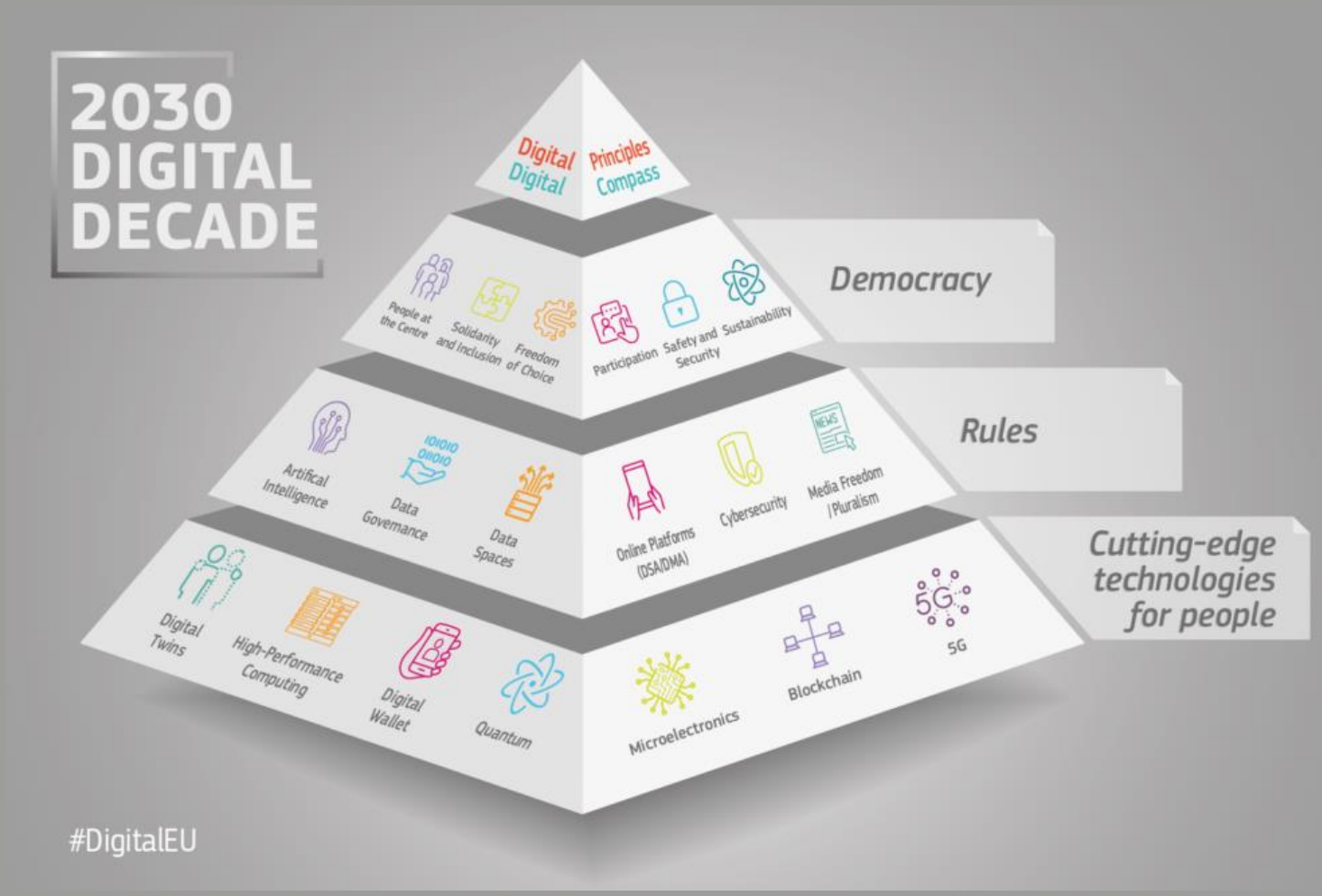


Europe's Digital Decade

Strategic priorities

1. High Performance Computing
2. AI, Data & Cloud
3. Cybersecurity & Trust
4. Advanced Digital Skills
5. Accelerating the Best Use of Digital
6. Semiconductors

Europe is creating the digital foundations for the next decades and investing billions in digital transformation.



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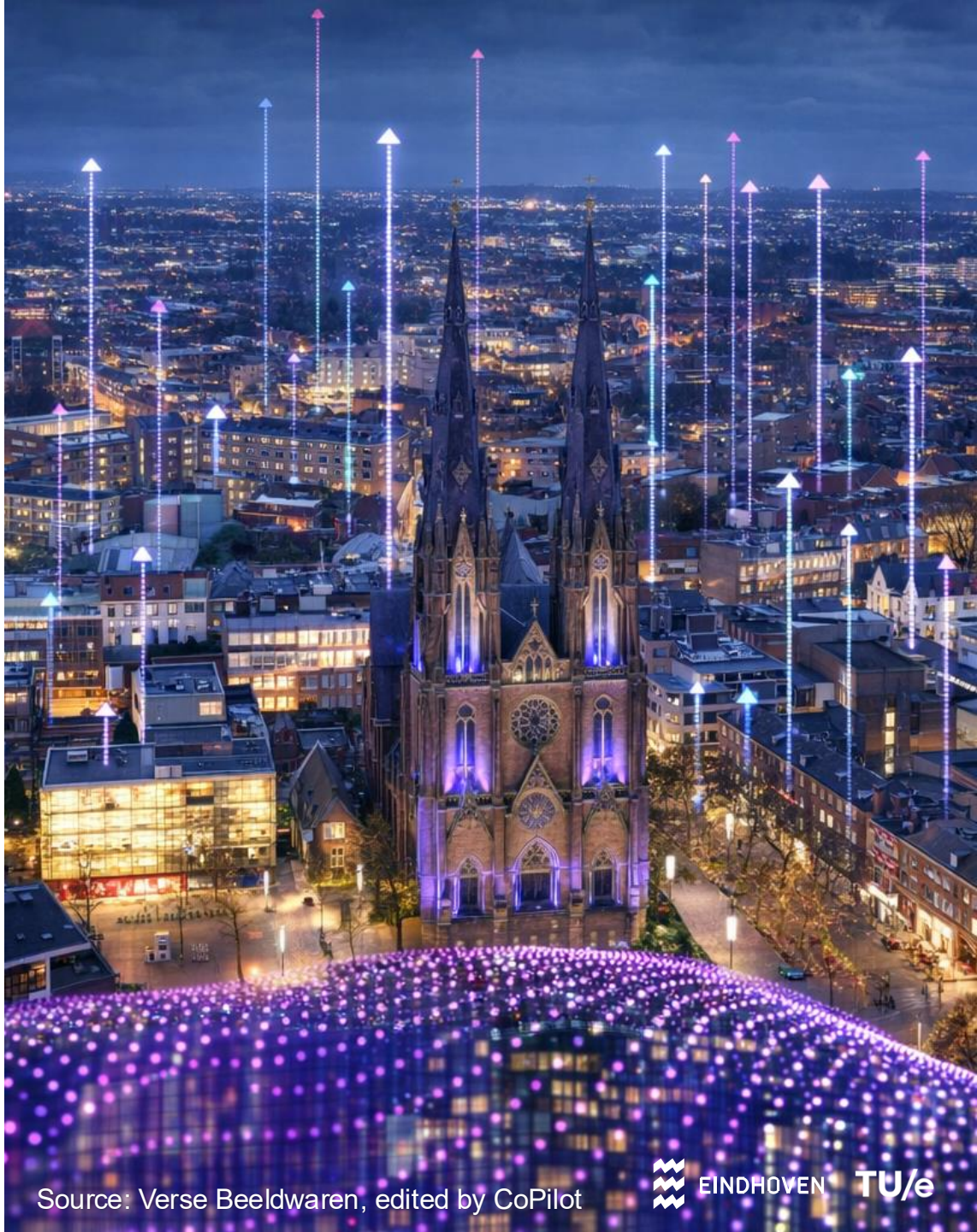
Impact on us?

Digitalization is no longer an IT issue. It is a public value issue. Every municipality must become:

- ✓ More digital
- ✓ More data-driven
- ✓ More resilient
- ✓ More AI-enabled
- ✓ More citizen-centric

And needs to collaborate even more

Without losing trust.



Source: Verse Beeldwaren, edited by CoPilot

From European strategy to local action

1. **Digital Sovereignty:** Reducing dependency on large providers.
2. **Digital Sustainability:** Sustainable digital infrastructure and reduction of carbon footprint.
3. **Responsible and human centric AI:** Human-centered and trustworthy AI.
4. **Cybersecurity & Resilience:** Protecting citizens and services.
5. **Digital Inclusion:** Nobody left behind.
6. **Data Strategy:** Data as a strategic asset.
7. **Immersive Technologies:** Preparing for future interaction models.



Source: Generated with CoPilot

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Looking beyond today

“Any idea about the future should appear to be ridiculous” – Jim Dator

1. Rapid city growth is creating challenges and opportunities across all municipal domains.

2. The Crow’s Nest (Kraaiennest) was established to anticipate long-term trends, risks, and emerging developments.

3. It helps the municipality look beyond immediate priorities and prepare strategically for the future.

HET EINDHOVEN VAN DE TOEKOMST


Source: Living Lab 040



Source: René Paré

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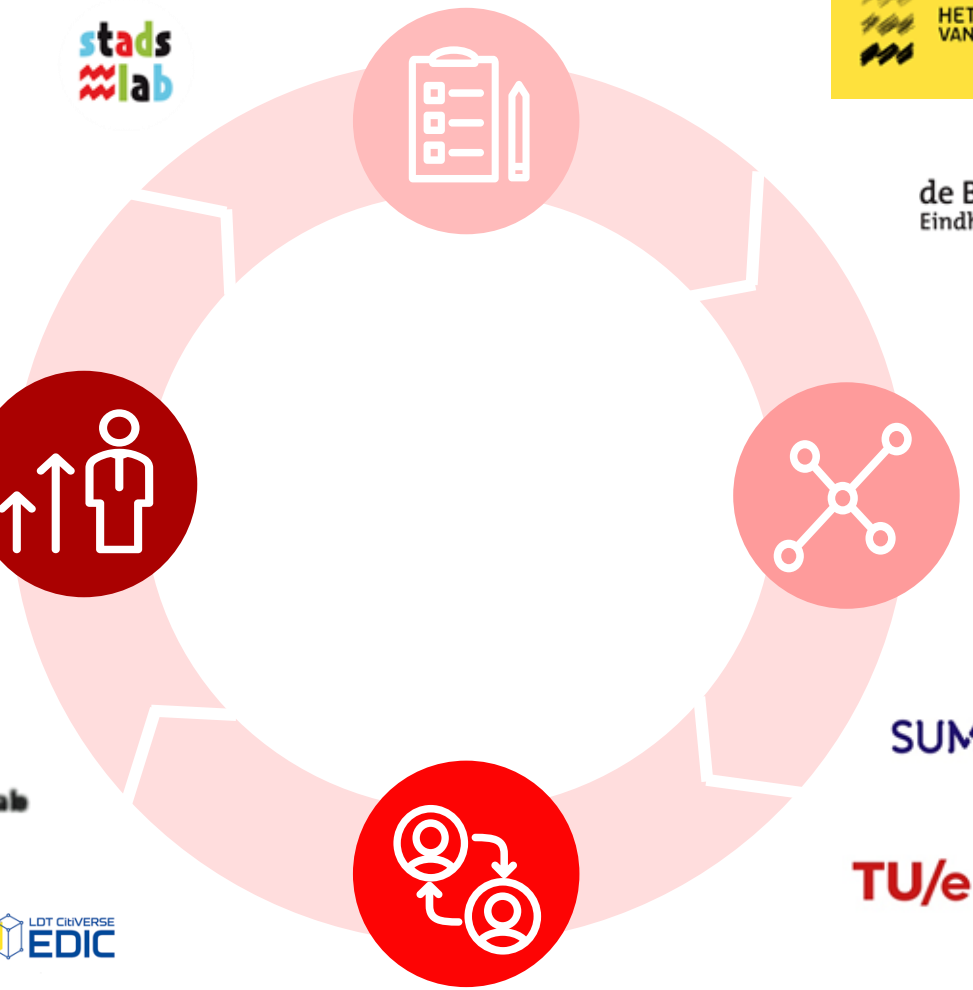


Translating strategy into reality

How do you transform strategy into innovation that citizens actually experience?

Source: Generated with CoPilot

Our model



1. IDENTIFY SOCIETAL PROBLEM
Based on actual needs of the city and its citizens.

2. EXPERIMENT
Start small and involve privacy, security and legal experts early.

3. VALIDATE
Test with real users and measure impact

4. SCALE
Create executive support and scale responsibly

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stads lab
HET EINDHOVEN VAN DE TOEKOMST
de Bibliotheek Eindhoven
Urban Data Centre
BRAINPORT EINDHOVEN
CitCom
CIVIC
FONTYS ICT InnovationLab
START UP SCHOOL
innovation Space
LDT CitiVERSE EDIC
BOM
SUMMA
SiNTLUCAS
HIGH TECH CAMPUS EINDHOVEN
TU/e
DAE Design Academy Eindhoven
Fontys
INNOVATION CENTER BRAINPORT
EINDHOVEN
TU/e

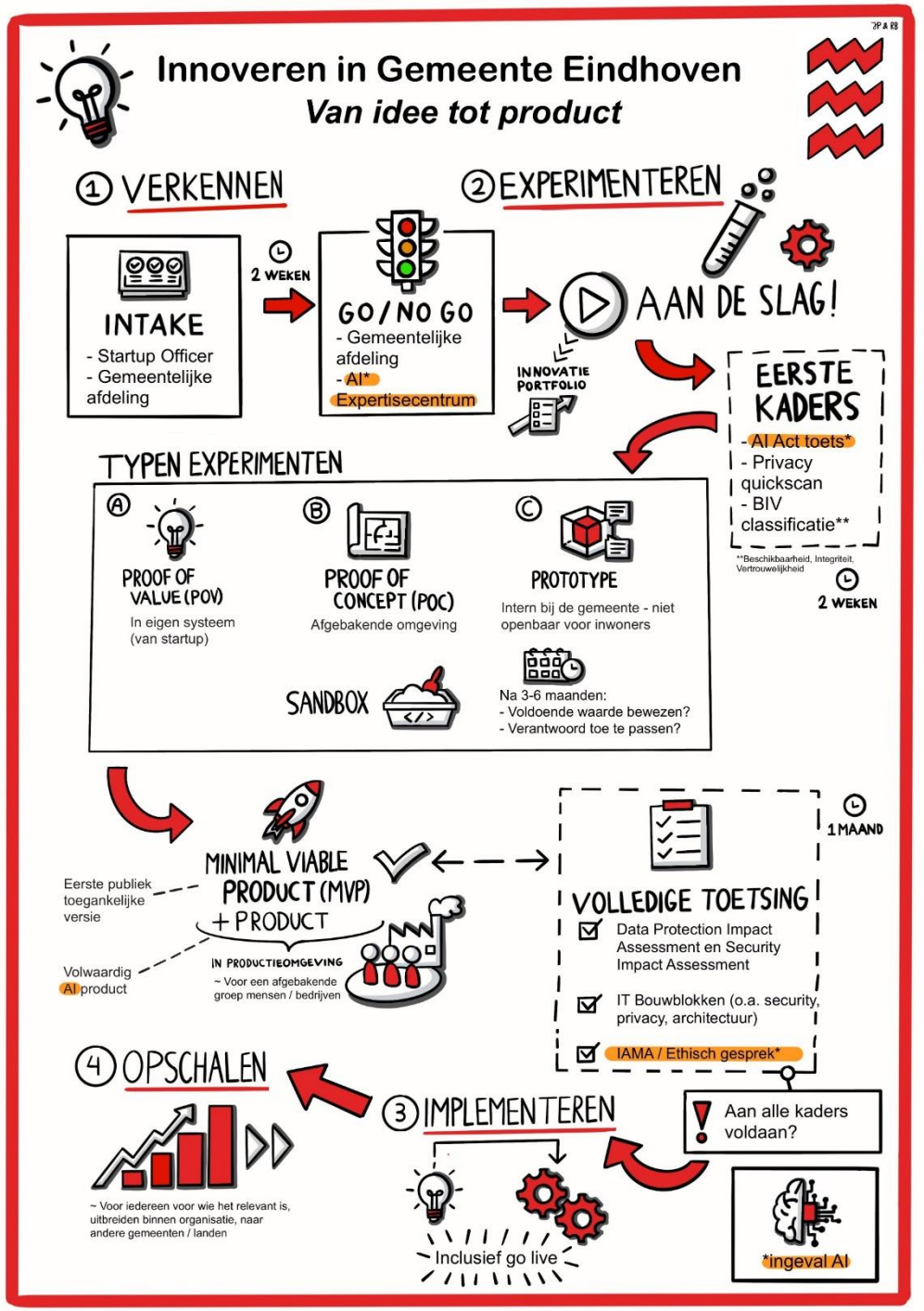
Our scorecard for innovation

Not every idea enters the portfolio!

Assessment Framework for Innovation Portfolio	
1	Alignment with a KIA social challenge (mobility, climate & energy, inclusion, housing)
2	Impact on the city
3	Involvement of quadruple helix (knowledge institutions, societal partners, businesses, citizens)
4	Scalability and business model
5	Maturity of the (technical) solution



How does this work?



Visual: Janneke Pladet, Romar Bucur

JP & RB

Innoveren in Gemeente Eindhoven

Van idee tot product

① VERKENNEN

INTAKE

- Startup Officer
- Gemeentelijke afdeling

2 WEKEN

GO / NO GO

- Gemeentelijke afdeling
- AI* Expertisecentrum

② EXPERIMENTEREN

INNOVATIE PORTFOLIO

AAN DE SLAG!

EERSTE KADERS

- AI Act toets*
- Privacy quickscan
- BIV classificatie**

**Beschikbaarheid, Integriteit, Vertrouwelijkheid

2 WEKEN

TYPEN EXPERIMENTEN

Ⓐ **PROOF OF VALUE (POV)**

Ⓑ **PROOF OF CONCEPT (POC)**

Ⓒ **PROTOTYPE**

Intern bij de gemeente - niet

- Startup Officer
- Gemeentelijke afdeling

- Gemeentelijke afdeling
- AI* Expertisecentrum

INNOVATIE PORTFOLIO

EERSTE KADERS

- AI Act toets*
- Privacy quickscan
- BIV classificatie**

**Beschikbaarheid, Integriteit, Vertrouwelijkheid

2 WEKEN

TYPEN EXPERIMENTEN

Ⓐ

PROOF OF VALUE (POV)

In eigen systeem (van startup)

Ⓑ

PROOF OF CONCEPT (POC)

Afgebakende omgeving

Ⓒ

PROTOTYPE

Intern bij de gemeente - niet openbaar voor inwoners

SANDBOX

Na 3-6 maanden:
- Voldoende waarde bewezen?
- Verantwoord toe te passen?

MINIMAL VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP)

Eerste publiek toegankelijke versie

+ PRODUCT IN PRODUCTIEOMGEVING

Volwaardig

VOLLEDIGE TOETSING

- [x] Data Protection Impact Assessment en Security Impact Assessment

1 MAAND

- Voldoende waarde bewezen?
- Verantwoord toe te passen?

MINIMAL VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP)
+ PRODUCT

Eerste publiek toegankelijke versie

Volwaardig AI product

IN PRODUCTIEOMGEVING

~ Voor een afgebakende groep mensen / bedrijven

1 MAAND

VOLLEDIGE TOETSING

- Data Protection Impact Assessment en Security Impact Assessment
- IT Bouwblokken (o.a. security, privacy, architectuur)
- IAMA / Ethisch gesprek*

Aan alle kaders voldaan?

*ingeval AI

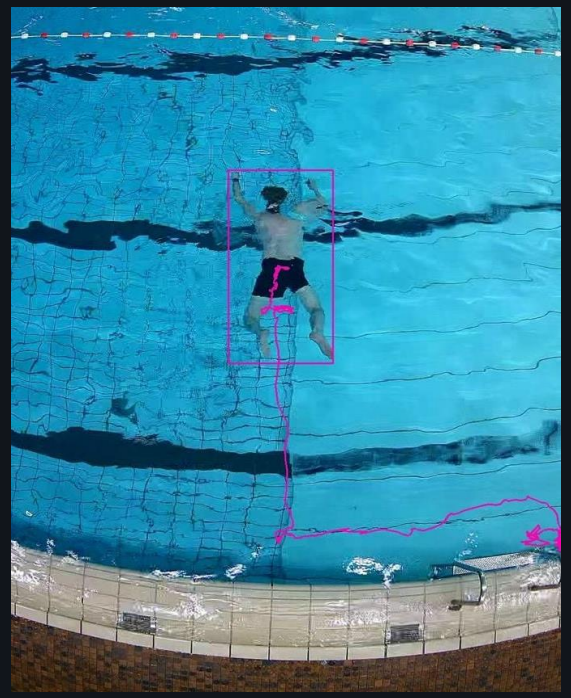
3 IMPLEMENTEREN

Inclusief go live

4 OPSCHALEN

~ Voor iedereen voor wie het relevant is, uitbreiden binnen organisatie, naar andere gemeenten / landen

Some examples



Ocuma
Smart technology to prevent drowing in Tongelreep.



Naext
Inclusive technology to find your way in public spaces.



Digital Sundai
Chatbot for expats coming to live, work and study in our region.



Hackathon
Grid Congestion hackathon of 48 hours.

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Our key learnings

The biggest misconception

Innovation is not a technology problem.

Innovation is an organizational problem.

Technology scales in months

Organisations scale in years

The difficult part is compliance, governance, stakeholder management and scaling.



Source: Nick Bookelaar

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This is where you come in

Government cannot innovate alone.

Universities provide:

- ✓ **Research**
- ✓ **Talent**
- ✓ **Independent validation**
- ✓ **Ethics**
- ✓ **Experimentation environments**



Source: Bart van Overbeeke

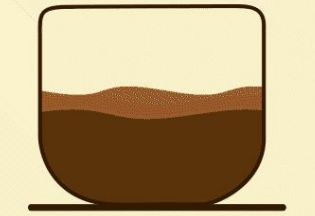
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The challenge for after the coffee break

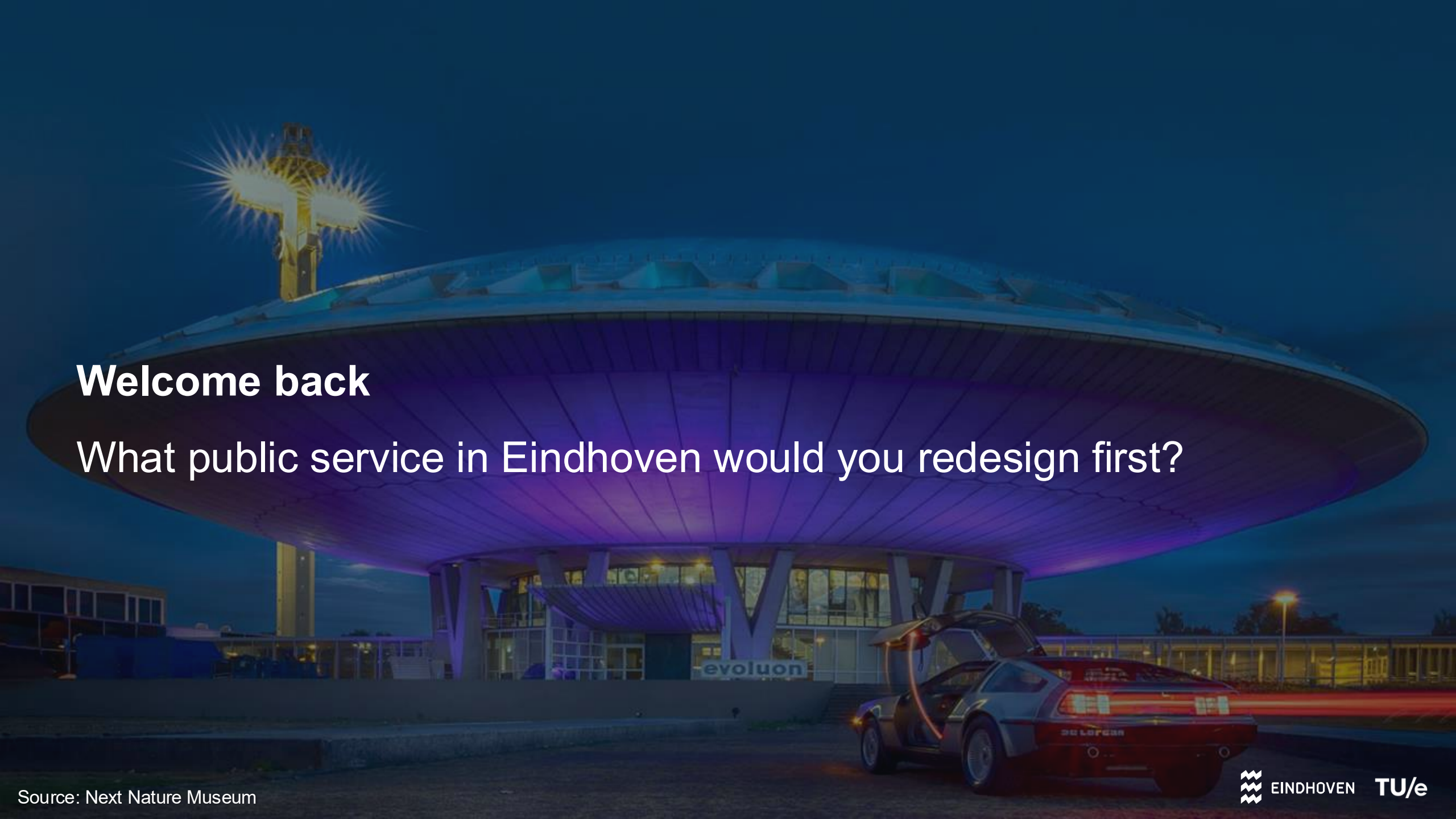
You receive:

- ✓ **€50,000**
- ✓ **Access to AI and your own team**
- ✓ **Six months**

What public service in Eindhoven would you redesign first?



Source: MD Al Amin



Welcome back

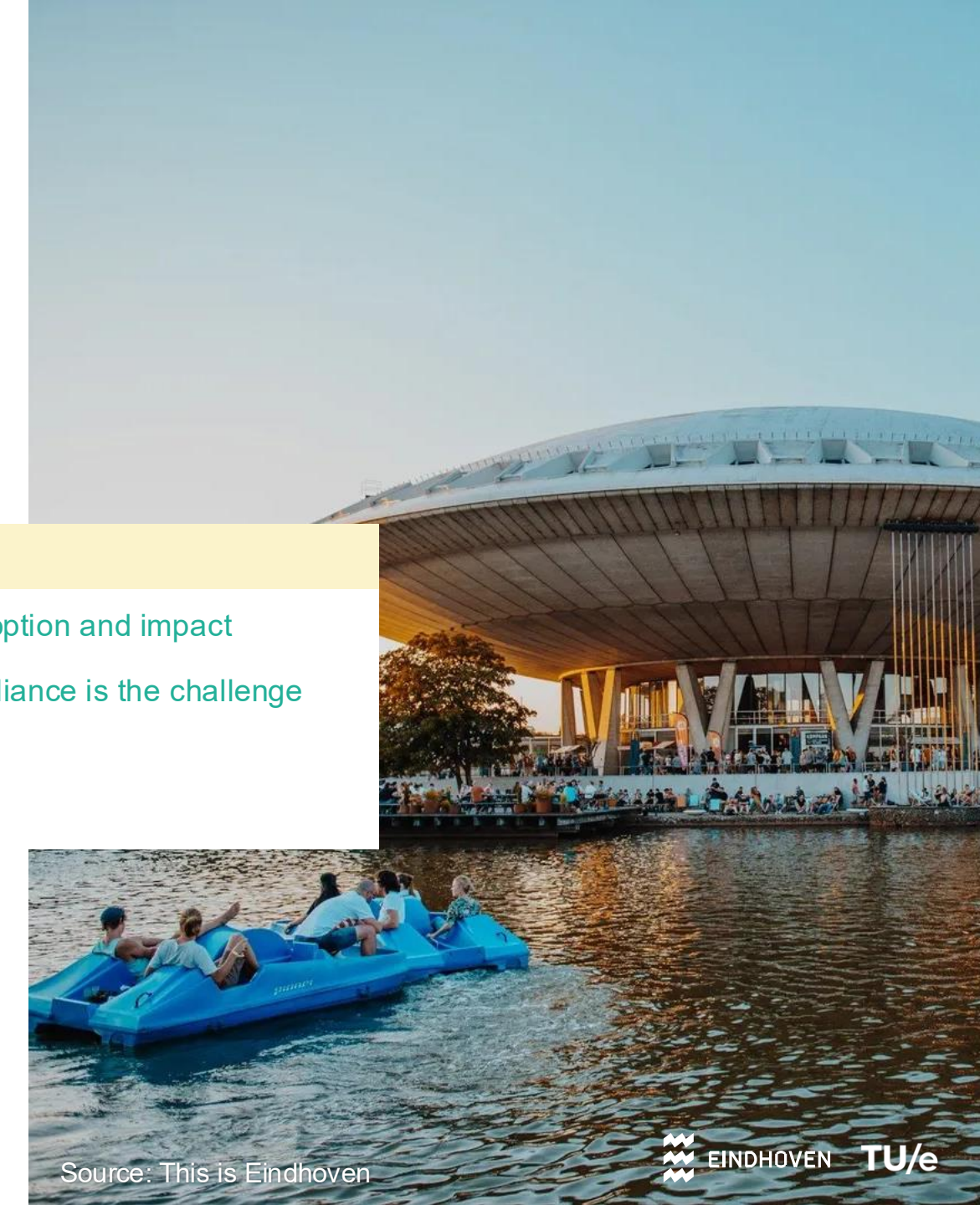
What public service in Eindhoven would you redesign first?

Source: Next Nature Museum

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What nobody tells you about public innovation

MYTH	REALITY
Innovation is about technology	Innovation is about adoption and impact
AI is the challenge	Governance and compliance is the challenge
Building is hard	Scaling is hard
Rules block innovation	Rules create trust



Source: This is Eindhoven

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From Red Tape to Public Value

The future of public innovation is not about moving around the rules.

It is about creating impact while respecting the rules.

That is how trust and innovation can coexist.



Source: Kas van Vliet

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Thank you! Questions?



Romar Bucur
Strategy | Innovation | Business Development | AI | Digital | C-Level Advisory



Gaby Rasters
Strategisch adviseur Kraaiennest
Gemeente Eindhoven ✦ Altijd ins...